Some weeks later, the doctor cut more of my nail off. This time he broke an ampule, squirted some liquid on the toe, and the skin turned white.

"What's that?" I asked in astonishment.

"Ethyl chloride," he said, cutting away deftly.

"Ethyl chloride! Then what did you use the first time?"

"I just washed it in alcohol."

Goodness! The first cutting had been made without anesthesia, and I had been so convinced the nail was frozen, I had felt nothing.

9

Occasionally, I walked guard in another make-believe aspect of Army life. On the night of December 10, I had the pleasure of breaking my guard shift on a bed's bare springs, with a rolled-up mattress as pillow and with all my clothes on.

The next day I got my first Army pay, $36.30. It in no way compensated. 5

10

My mail was copious enough. Sprague de Camp was a particularly faithful correspondent, and I even heard from William Boyd of Boston University, who wrote to tell me how much he liked "The Mule." As for Marcia, she sent me a 1946 diary so that I might continue my daily recordings.

By all odds the most interesting item I read was not in any letter, though. On December 17, 1945, I came across an article in the Army Times for December 15, which dealt with a new Army order that allowed the release of chemists engaged in research.

That galvanized me into activity at once. For over a year before induction I had done whatever I could legitimately do to avoid induction; and now it was my intention to do whatever I could legitimately do to gain release.

The thought of doing something, of arranging interviews, of marshaling arguments in my mind, made a little more bearable such ridiculous activities as bayonet practice and marches in full field pack through melting snow and slush.